

FIELD NOTE



The Market Is Terrain, Not Author

*On brand evolution, brand drift, and the difference
nobody can see from inside it.*

Every organization believes it is listening to the market. The question worth asking is who is doing the talking.

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The Flag Football World Championships take place in Garath, on the southern edge of Düsseldorf, at an outdoor complex the city built two years ago with the New England Patriots. We drove down this past weekend — my son Jackson had been counting down for weeks — and by the time we arrived under a gray August sky he had a plan for the day: every booth, every game they'd let him play, and the ball. The REVO, Wilson's new ball built specifically for the flag game, had already sold out by the time we reached their tent. We ordered one on the spot anyway, and the team running the booth handed Jackson a demo model to play with for the rest of the afternoon, calling him, only half joking, "the future." Whatever else the day gave us, that's the image that stayed — a company's own people, out on the grass, treating a ten-year-old like the whole reason the product existed. I didn't think about it again as an idea until the drive home, when it had become one.

Ask a marketing leader whether their brand is evolving or drifting and you'll get an answer in about two seconds. Ask how they know, and the answer takes considerably longer, or never arrives. That gap is worth taking seriously, because it isn't a failure of honesty. No brand has ever drifted on purpose — that sentence sounds like a truism, but it contains the whole problem. Organizations don't misdiagnose drift because they're careless or dishonest about it. They misdiagnose it because, from the inside, drift and evolution are experienced identically. Both feel like responsiveness. Both feel like maturity. Both arrive in the room as a reasonable answer to a real pressure: a client who needs the tone warmer, a quarter that needs a discount, a competitor who got somewhere first, a category that has visibly moved and won't wait. Every one of those pressures is genuine, and every response to them is defensible on the day it's made. The people making the calls aren't asleep. They're doing exactly what they were hired to do, which is to listen to the market and act on what they hear. And so an organization in the middle of a slow abandonment of everything it stood for describes itself, sincerely and without irony, as customer-led. It isn't lying. It has no vantage point from which to see otherwise. Drift feels like listening the entire time it's happening, which is what makes it drift rather than evolution: all response, no thesis.

The instinctive way to draw the line is intention versus entropy. Evolution is chosen; drift is what happens when nobody chooses. Evolution has an author and a date. Drift is discovered in hindsight — the accumulated residue of a tone softened for one client, a standard bent for one quarter, a promise dropped because keeping it got dangerous. It's a satisfying distinction, and it fails as a primary test, because most of what gets called drift was actually decided. Someone sat in a room and chose to chase the trend, dilute the promise, follow the category downmarket. There were slides. There was a business case. That was a decision, and a bad one — which means that if intention is the test, every bad decision

gets to reclassify itself as evolution, and the word stops doing any work. The intent axis is exculpatory, not merely imprecise: it converts authorship into justification, when authorship was never what made evolution evolution in the first place. Bad strategy is authored too. “We evolved, it just didn’t land” is the most comfortable lie in brand strategy, and the intention test hands it over for free.

The cut that survives contact with reality is fidelity versus abandonment — whether a move deepens the thesis or trades it away. Evolution keeps the core and updates the expression. The brand still knows what it is; it now knows it differently, in terms the present world can receive, and the through-line stays nameable. Someone in the building can say what changed, why, and what it’s supposed to do now, and the answer connects back to what the brand was already for. Abandonment inverts that relationship. The expression may barely move — same logo, same language, same taglines — while the thing underneath stops meaning what it used to. That’s the failure nobody catches, because the surface stays frozen while the substance erodes, and a brand that looks identical to what it was is a hard thing to convince that it’s no longer the same object.

Netflix is the clean version of what fidelity actually looks like. The DVD-by-mail business and the streaming business share almost no operational DNA — warehouses and red envelopes gave way to content delivery networks and licensing negotiations, and by any surface reading the company became something else entirely. But the thesis never moved: get people the thing they want to watch without the friction of going to get it. Streaming was the promise finally becoming technically possible, and the company had said so, on the record, for a decade before the bandwidth arrived. The name was a bet on it from the beginning. The expression changed completely. The core didn’t move an inch.

Which answers the original question, or at least reframes it. If a brand moves to meet the market, is that drift or evolution? Neither, by itself. “Moving to meet the market” is a maneuver more than a category, and it serves either master. What decides which one you’re looking at is what the brand arrived carrying, more than whether it moved. Move toward the market and arrive still holding your thesis, with the same core and a new expression meeting a genuine shift in how people live, and you’ve closed the distance between what you are and where the world now is without becoming something else to do it. That’s evolution. Move toward the market by shedding your thesis, adopting the trend because that’s where the attention is, letting the category tell you what to be, and you’ve handed over the pen. In evolution the market is terrain. It becomes the author only when you let it — and at that moment, you’ve already left.

Having demoted intent, it shouldn’t be discarded entirely. It’s no longer the primary axis, though it remains a critical secondary one, because it separates two failures that need completely different responses. Once fidelity becomes the cut, most of what gets called drift turns out to sit on the wrong

side of it by choice — decided deviation, not drift: a conscious abandonment of thesis, with an author, a date, and a rationale you can contest. LEGO in the late nineties is the clearest case. The expansion into clothing, watches, publishing, video games, and theme parks was authored and defended at every step. The brand was a lifestyle, the brick was treated as a limitation, and growth was expected to live somewhere else. By 2003 the company was reportedly some eight hundred million dollars in debt, posting losses near three hundred million. The correction under Jørgen Vig Knudstorp was an argument won, not a mood recovered: the brick system is the thesis. SKUs were roughly halved, the video-game division and the theme parks were sold off, and the core came back. Revenue quadrupled over the following decade. A decided error, reversed by a decision.

A residual category survives this demotion, though, and it's the real thing. Gap's decline resists a single villain the way LEGO's doesn't. No memo announced the abandonment of American casual essentials. Leadership turned over repeatedly, with no tenure long enough to course-correct, and the assortment chased fashion, retreated to basics, and chased fashion again, blurring the identity one reasonable quarter at a time while faster competitors defined themselves sharply against it. What followed was roughly two decades of trying to work out what the brand was supposed to be. There's no room to storm and no decision to reverse, because no one ever chose to leave the thesis behind — it eroded underneath a hundred locally sensible calls that never summed to a choice anyone could point to. The intervention there is installation, not argument — putting a thesis back where one had gone missing, because there's no counterparty left to argue with.

That's the reason to hold the two failures apart, and it's operational rather than philosophical. Decided deviation is corrected by argument — you contest the thesis, you win, and it reverses by the same mechanism that created it. Drift can't be argued with, because there's nobody on the other side of the table. Bring a persuasive deck to a drift problem and it lands on no one. Different disease, different intervention.

The test, in practice, comes down to three things a room can actually be asked out loud, and how badly the room wants to avoid answering is itself part of what you learn. Can anyone name the through-line — the constant, not the change, stated in one sentence without reaching for the tagline? A room that can't produce it is relocating, and calling that evolution won't make it so. Who authored the move, the brand or the market — did the thesis have anything to say about the shift before the shift became commercially attractive, or did the opportunity do all the talking? And did the gap close or widen — is the distance between how the brand sees itself and how the world experiences it narrowing, or has it been getting away from everyone for longer than anyone wants to admit? None of the three asks how the strategy feels, and that's deliberate. The feeling is the one instrument everyone in the room already knows to be broken.

There's a phrase worth striking from the vocabulary entirely, and it's misguided evolution. It sounds like rigor. It functions as an alibi. It takes an act of abandonment — a moment when you knew your thesis, understood what it demanded, and traded it for the trend anyway — and launders it through a word that implies growth, converting a decision into something more like weather. If a brand deviated from its core on purpose, that deserves to be named as its own error, with its own author, not absorbed into the vocabulary of progress. And if a brand eroded without anyone deciding anything, that deserves naming too, as the harder problem it actually is. Both failures are survivable. Both are correctable. Neither becomes correctable until it's named accurately, and the vocabulary most organizations reach for is built, however unintentionally, to prevent exactly that.

I keep coming back to this past weekend already — not because it proves anything, it's one afternoon on one field, and I'd be doing exactly the thing I'm warning against if I tried to make it stand for more than it was. But there was a feeling out on those fields, walking them with a ten-year-old who wanted to know why some companies were there and some weren't, that had nothing to do with slide decks or quarterly numbers. It was just presence or its absence, plain enough that a kid could clock it without anyone explaining the theory to him. Some companies had shown up carrying whatever they'd told the world they were. Others hadn't, and the fields didn't care why. Fidelity is the question, not change. The market is terrain, not author, and the ones who lose it are the ones who hand over the pen while sincerely believing, the whole time, that they were only listening.

